THE PATRIARCH STRIKES BACK
Sharad Pawar withdrawing his resignation as NCP chief at a press conference in Mumbai

future. Ajit has the necessary numbers in the legislature party as the BJP high command is monitoring this operation... Pawar's resignation was born out of a sense of frustration and uneasiness at the machinations of those who wanted to go with the BJP," says a senior leader of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray). But he adds that even if the NCP split down the middle, the octogenarian Pawar still has the energy and spunk to organise a fightback.

A close aide of the Pawars feels Ajit is unlikely to join the BJP per se, but is eager to ensure the NCP aligns itself that way as a party. "Ajit dada's

DESPITE PAWAR'S SHOW OF STRENGTH, THE ELEPHANTS IN THE ROOM HAVE NOT DISAPPEARED

aggressive temperament and style of functioning will not gel with the BJP leadership. He will not be comfortable with anyone dictating terms to him... He also cannot afford to split from Pawar as he, Pawar and Sule jointly control a network of cooperatives and institutions and also share a common electoral catchment," he explains. But the perception of an anti-incumbency sentiment against the Shinde-Fadnavis regime has forced the BJP to look for new allies. And Ajit is a "soft target".

"Pawar bowled a googly to stop Ajit and to show his command over the NCP. He also underlined his national role, with Rahul Gandhi, M.K. Stalin, Sitaram Yechury et al requesting him to reconsider his move," says senior editor Nikhil Wagle. At the very least, he feels, a diminished Ajit is likely to reconsider his moves to align with the BJP. ■

TRINAMOOL

GROWING NEW ROOTS

By Romita Datta

For years now, Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee's nephew and chosen heir as party chief, has been trying to fill out his role as future supremo by spearheading a kind of ethical cleansing. Target: the high-handed leaders operating with impunity despite all-pervasive allegations of corruption sullying their name—and, in turn, the party's. In this, the 35-year-old crossed swords with TMC veterans, even dared to disagree with Mamata. His crusade continued in the aftermath of the arrests of former education minister Partha Chatterjee in the alleged teachers' recruitment scam in July 2022 and party heavyweight Anubrata Mondal in the cattle smuggling racket in August. A cabinet rejig saw fresh faces, several of them close to Abhishek. As popular outrage mounted over the scams as well as a string of crimes allegedly connected to party workers, Abhishek promised real change, real fast. Posters appeared

ENDORSING THE YOUNG
Mamata and Abhishek Banerjee at the Jan Sanjog Yatra rally in Malda, May 4



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